

nists with religious bigots, saying it was against our culture, sexist and morally corrupting. But it's amusing to see that all these so-called decadent Western phenomena match quite effortlessly with our good old feudal values like the arranged marriage market and buttress them. If the ideal of an international class is the minimal lean mean Kareena Kapoor in designer clothes, the desis love the heavily ornamented *bahus* of the K serials. I'm amazed at the number of jewellery shops — is there a recession? In fact, much of the consumerism here revolves around marriage and dowry.

NR And fashion shows seem to have caught Indian imagination, right?

PN Walking the ramp is a rage everywhere and is an integral part of Indian culture now. All annual college functions have fashion shows. It fits in seamlessly with our yearning for past glories and our anxieties about caste and religion. Our fashion designers survive on their Punjabi wedding outfits. One of our fashion gurus who was incarcerated in Dubai some years ago passed the time by training his fellow jail inmates how to walk the ramp, which apparently had a spiritual effect. Walking the ramp seems to satisfy some deep atavistic need in us, perhaps it goes back to our ancient custom of the *swayamvar*, or even the traditional marriage selection interview, where the girl was asked questions, told to thread a needle, and to walk up and down to check whether all her faculties and limbs were in working order.

NR (laughs) Do you think we are obsessed by beauty?

PN Well, recession or not, one business which is thriving and expanding in India is the beauty parlour. You find beauty parlours in the poorest slums and farthest boondocks. This is in a country, mind you, where most people lack piped water or sanitary systems, leave alone literacy or public health care. And these beauty parlours, amusingly, have blonde blue-eyed models advertised on their signboards.

Colonialism is like a mind parasite. And while there is this whole cornucopia of cosmetics and toiletries to beautify us, our towns and countryside are being uglified relentlessly, from factories dumping toxic waste, filth and garbage, to mindless unplanned demolitions and building. So while the European cities we so admire remain beautiful museum pieces, we make our habitats ugly and unhealthy. The worst epidemics of cholera, hepatitis and plague start in our richest cities.

NR Gyms are flourishing too, sometimes three or four on a street.

PN As in everything else, our film stars set the trend. It takes so much energy to make the pelvic thrusts and bosom shud-

ders in filmy dances that they've taken to weight lifting, building six-packs and power yoga, inspiring the nation. But yoga has not really caught on in a big way with Indians, perhaps because it is actually traditional and has no exotic appeal besides being usually taught by conservative old fogies. I must admit I've started going to the gym lately to keep fit, in a gentle geriatric way. But the biggest racket now is the Ayurvedic massage spa, which is spreading out from Kerala with an unstoppable centrifugal force and is our latest gift to the world.

NR How do you think globalisation and liberalisation of the economy have affected our self-image?

PN It has created a culture of the surface, from economic and political policies to a general obsession with trivialities, or in trivialising everything. There's a strange idea that multiplying luxury goods will benefit the poor. It's like the icing on a mud cake, and the icing has only shown up the ugly poverty in the country, the kind of poverty that is not found anywhere else in the world except in sub-Saharan Africa.

The media is the worst manifestation of this. A leading paper had horrific pictures of the Gujarat riots next to photographs of the latest modelling contest on the front page. All images become equal and saleable, pain and suffering become prod-

Fair PLAY

2000 Lara Dutta and Priyanka Chopra win the Miss Universe and Miss World titles respectively, recreating 1994.

2002 The Kaya Skin Clinic is launched.

2003 German hair colour major Henkel Schwarzkopf follows brands like L'Oreal and Revlon into the Indian hair colour market. The idea is to reach out to the 20 per cent of Indian women who colour their hair and tap the Rs 650-crore industry.

2005 The dark-fair debate grabs eyeballs with the main protagonist of *Saat Phere* (Zee TV) becoming a rage among the viewers. The tradition continues with *Bidaai* on Star Plus that began in 2007.

2006 Botox is available on prescription.



2006 Salman Khan visits Dubai for hair transplants.

2007 Terms like body contouring find place in Indian vocabulary as theories abound on how Shah Rukh Khan acquired his six-pack.

CHILDREN
WALK IN WITH
their mothers
for surgery.
Today's society
is largely
driven by what
children want.

DR MILIND
WAGH,
COSMETIC
SURGEON